

KARNATAKA & TAMIL NADU ORIGIN

Rava Dosa

Crispy Instant Semolina Lace Crepes
The Fastest Crisp on Any South Indian Breakfast Table

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Rava Dosa

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Rava Dosa

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Dosa That Needs No Fermentation

For all the glory of the classic dosa, there is one unavoidable truth: making it properly requires hours of soaking, grinding, and fermenting. The rava dosa sweeps all of that away. Made from semolina (rava), rice flour, and maida, its batter is mixed and used immediately — no grinding, no waiting, no overnight planning. It is ready in fifteen minutes and cooks in three.

What it lacks in fermentation-sourness, it more than compensates for in texture. Rava dosa is famous for its characteristic lace pattern — a network of holes and thin, translucent, almost shatteringly crisp panels. This distinctive structure arises from the thin, almost watery batter being poured from height and allowed to run freely across the hot tawa, creating irregular pockets of crispness that no regular dosa can replicate.

The rava dosa became a restaurant staple across Karnataka and Tamil Nadu in the mid-20th century, prized precisely because it could be made on demand without a day's advance preparation. Today it appears on every major Udupi restaurant menu, often listed simply as 'onion rava dosa' — the most beloved version, loaded with finely chopped onions, green chillies, and a shower of fresh coriander.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Dosa That Needs No Fermentation, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

One of the most ordered items at Udupi restaurants across India — prized for its instant preparation and dramatic lacy appearance. Onion rava dosa is the classic version; plain rava dosa (without toppings) is occasionally served, but the onion version is far more popular. Unlike regular dosa, rava dosa is never fermented — a significant advantage for same-day breakfast preparation or when idli-dosa batter is unavailable. The dramatic pouring technique — from height, in a circular pattern — is part of the theatrical quality of watching a skilled cook make rava dosa.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

15m	20m	30m	4 (8 dosas)	Medium
ACTIVE PREP	REST TIME	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Heavy cast iron tawa or flat griddle (minimum 30 cm diameter for restaurant-size dosa)
- Large ladle (¾ cup / 180 ml capacity) — the pouring ladle for rava dosa is larger than for regular dosa
- Flat thin spatula (a very thin, wide spatula is essential for lifting the delicate lace without tearing)
- Small bowl or squeeze bottle for oil
- Whisk for mixing batter

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Rava dosa batter can be refrigerated for up to 8 hours — no longer, as the semolina continues to absorb water and the batter thickens. Stir well before using and add a splash of water if too thick. The batter should always be poured thin and watery. Cooked dosas do not store — serve immediately after cooking, as the crispness disappears within minutes.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the rava dosa

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Fine semolina (rava / sooji)	½ cup	80 g	½ katori
Rice flour	½ cup	60 g	½ katori
All-purpose flour (maida)	2 tbsp	16 g	2 tbsp
Onion, very finely chopped	1 medium	100 g	1 medium
Green chillies, minced	2	2	2
Fresh coriander, finely chopped	3 tbsp	12 g	3 tbsp
Fresh ginger, grated	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Cumin seeds	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Black pepper, coarsely crushed	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Salt	¾ tsp	4 g	to taste
Water (for batter)	2–2¼ cups	480–540 ml	as needed
Oil (for cooking)	2–3 tsp per dosa	10–15 ml	2–3 chammach

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Fine rava (semolina) is essential — coarse semolina will give a grainy texture rather than a crisp one. Rice flour is non-negotiable and gives rava dosa its characteristic crispness; do not skip it or substitute with more maida. The small amount of maida acts as a binder and helps the lacy structure hold together. For a gluten-free version, replace the maida with an additional tablespoon of rice flour, though the structure will be slightly more fragile.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Mixing & Resting the Batter

01 COMBINE THE DRY INGREDIENTS

In a large bowl, whisk together the fine semolina, rice flour, and maida. Add the salt and mix well to distribute evenly.

02 ADD AROMATICS AND WATER

Add the finely chopped onion, minced green chillies, coriander, grated ginger, cumin seeds, and crushed pepper to the dry mixture. Pour in 2 cups (480 ml) of water gradually while whisking continuously until the batter is completely smooth and very thin — much thinner than regular dosa batter. It should resemble thin buttermilk or a very thin crepe batter.

Chef tip. The batter must be thin enough to pour freely from the ladle. The runnier it is, the lacier the dosa. Begin with 2 cups of water and add more if needed — different brands of semolina absorb water at different rates.

03 REST THE BATTER

Allow the batter to rest for 15–20 minutes. During this time, the semolina absorbs the water, swells slightly, and the batter thickens a little. After resting, stir well — the batter should still be thin and watery. If it has become too thick, add water tablespoon by tablespoon until it is thin and pourable.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Mixing & Resting the Batter, continued



COOKING CHECKPOINT

Correct batter consistency is the entire secret of rava dosa. Tilt the bowl — the batter should flow freely to the edges within 2–3 seconds, like thin soup. If it flows slowly like pancake batter, it is too thick and will not make the characteristic lacy structure. Add more water until it is very thin.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

The Pouring Technique & Cooking

04 HEAT THE TAWA VERY HOT

Place the tawa over high heat and allow it to heat fully for 3–4 minutes. Rava dosa requires a hotter tawa than regular dosa — the rapid setting of the thin batter from a very hot surface is what creates the lace pattern. The tawa must be very hot before the first dosa.

05 POUR FROM HEIGHT IN CIRCLES

Drizzle oil lightly across the hot tawa. Fill the ladle with batter. Hold it about 15–20 cm above the tawa and pour in a quick circular motion from the outside edge inward, filling in any gaps with additional small pours. Do not spread with the ladle — pour only, allowing the batter to flow naturally and create its own pattern.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

The Pouring Technique & Cooking, continued



Chef tip. Pouring from height is the technique that creates the holes. The batter hits the hot tawa and immediately sets in irregular patterns. A ladle held too close to the surface produces a solid, hole-free dosa. Keep your arm high and move quickly.

06 DRIZZLE OIL AND COOK UNTIL CRISP

Drizzle a teaspoon of oil over the surface of the dosa and around the edges. Cook over high to medium-high heat for 3–4 minutes without touching until the edges are fully golden and lacy, and the surface has dried out completely — no wet spots anywhere.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

The Pouring Technique & Cooking, continued

07 FOLD AND SERVE

Rava dosa is typically only cooked on one side — unlike regular dosa, it is not flipped. When the entire surface is dry and golden, slide the thin spatula carefully under the dosa, fold it in half or into a cylinder, and serve immediately.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Attempting to flip a rava dosa often tears the delicate lacy structure. The dosa cooks entirely from the bottom up — the thin batter dries completely from the heat of the tawa without needing to be flipped. Remove it the moment the surface is fully dry.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Classic Style

- Served hot and immediately with sambar and coconut chutney.
- A tomato-based chutney or peanut chutney pairs particularly well with rava dosa, providing a savoury counterpoint to the crisp, subtly spiced dosa.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Masala Rava Dosa

- A spiced potato filling (the same masala used for masala dosa) placed in the fold before serving elevates rava dosa to a complete, very satisfying breakfast.
- The filling goes in during the last 30 seconds of cooking — the hot dosa warms it through without the masala needing to be separately heated.

Street-Style

- Street vendors often serve rava dosa with a liberal smear of a red garlic-chilli chutney inside the fold.
- Ghee drizzled over the finished dosa is a classic hotel-style finishing touch.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Temperature Management

- Maintain the tawa at high heat throughout cooking — rava dosa fails at medium or low heat. The batter must hit a very hot surface to create the lacy pattern.
- Between dosas, wipe the tawa with a halved onion or a damp cloth to remove residue and keep the surface clean and evenly hot.

The Thin Batter Rule

- The batter should always be thinner than feels natural. If in doubt, add more water — a rava dosa batter cannot be too thin, but it absolutely can be too thick.
- Re-stir the batter before every dosa — the semolina settles at the bottom within 5 minutes.

THE POURING ARM

Professional rava dosa makers hold the ladle with an extended arm and pour in one smooth circular sweep without hesitation. Practice the motion over an empty tawa to develop the muscle memory.

Multiple smaller pours can fill in the gaps — pour fast in a circle, then immediately fill obvious holes with the remaining batter in the ladle.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

140 kcal	3 g	24 g	4 g	1 g
CALORIES (PER DOSA)	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with preparation method and serving size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Gluten. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Onion Rava Dosa	The classic — fine-chopped onion cooked into the dosa for extra flavour and a slightly soft layer beneath the crisp exterior. The most ordered version at Udupi restaurants.
Masala Rava Dosa	Rava dosa with a spiced potato filling (aloo masala) folded inside — the most satisfying complete breakfast version.
Wheat Rava Dosa	Made with wheat semolina (dalia) rather than regular semolina — darker in colour, nuttier in flavour, slightly healthier.
Set Dosa	A thick, soft multi-dosa set — three small, slightly thick dosas served together — made from regular fermented batter; a Karnataka speciality that shares the rava dosa presentation of small multiple dosas.

My rava dosa has no holes – it came out solid like a regular dosa. What went wrong?

Two possible causes: the batter was too thick, or the tawa was not hot enough. Both prevent the thin-batter-lace formation. Make the batter significantly thinner (almost like water) and ensure the tawa is very hot — test with a water droplet that evaporates in under 1 second.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

The rava dosa is tearing when I try to remove it – how do I fix it?

The dosa was not cooked long enough. Wait until every part of the surface is completely dry with no wet shine — this takes 3–4 full minutes. A properly cooked rava dosa lifts from the tawa cleanly at the edges before you even apply the spatula.

Can I make the batter the night before?

No — rava dosa batter must be made and used the same day. The semolina absorbs water overnight and the batter thickens beyond recovery; it will not produce the characteristic lacy texture.

Why does my rava dosa taste different from the restaurant version?

The key differences are usually the tawa type (cast iron vs. non-stick) and heat level. Cast iron at high heat creates a more authentic crispness. Also ensure fresh cumin seeds and good-quality rice flour — old rice flour loses its crispness-producing quality.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Rava	semolina; fine-ground durum wheat sold as 'sooji' or 'rava' in Indian stores; fine variety is essential for rava dosa.
Rice flour	ground dried rice; the ingredient that gives rava dosa its signature crispness, available at any Indian or Asian grocery.
Maida	refined all-purpose flour; used in small quantities in rava dosa batter as a structural binder.
Onion rava dosa	the most popular restaurant variation of rava dosa; fine-chopped onion cooked directly into the lacy dosa.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Rava Dosa

15m ACTIVE PREP	20m REST TIME
30m COOK TIME	4 (8 dosas) SERVINGS
Medium DIFFICULTY	

RAVA DOSA

Fine semolina	80 g
Rice flour	60 g
All-purpose flour	16 g
Onion	100 g
Green chillies	2
Fresh coriander	12 g
Fresh ginger	4 g
Cumin seeds	1.5 g
Black pepper	1.5 g
Salt	4 g
Water	480–540 ml
Oil	10–15 ml

METHOD

01 **Combine the dry ingredients.** In a large bowl, whisk together the fine semolina, rice flour, and maida.

02 **Add aromatics and water.** Add the finely chopped onion, minced green chillies, coriander, grated ginger, cumin seeds, and crushed pepper to the dry mixture.

03 **Rest the batter.** Allow the batter to rest for 15–20 minutes.

04 **Heat the tawa very hot.** Place the tawa over high heat and allow it to heat fully for 3–4 minutes.

05 **Pour from height in circles.** Drizzle oil lightly across the hot tawa.

06 **Drizzle oil and cook until crisp.** Drizzle a teaspoon of oil over the surface of the dosa and around the edges.

07 **Fold and serve.** Rava dosa is typically only cooked on one side — unlike regular dosa, it is not flipped.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Fine semolina	80 g	☐ Rice flour	60 g
☐ All-purpose flour	16 g	☐ Onion	100 g
☐ Green chillies	2	☐ Fresh coriander	12 g
☐ Fresh ginger	4 g	☐ Cumin seeds	1.5 g
☐ Black pepper	1.5 g	☐ Salt	4 g
☐ Oil	10–15 ml		

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